

Loaded Headline Laboratory Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-35 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	loaded-headline-laboratory

Big idea: Wording frames interpretation.

Overview

Students see how word choice frames knowledge claims.

Student Prompt

Inspect Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A neutral claim rewritten as alarming, heroic, bureaucratic, and sceptical headlines. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Headline cards using verbs such as 'admits', 'claims', 'reveals', and 'warns'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Loaded Headline Laboratory Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A trust rating before and after students see the same evidence. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Wording frames interpretation.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Can language be neutral?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how wording frames interpretation.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A neutral claim rewritten as alarming, heroic, bureaucratic, and sceptical headlines.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A neutral claim rewritten as alarming, heroic, bureaucratic, and sceptical headlines.
- Headline cards using verbs such as 'admits', 'claims', 'reveals', and 'warns'.
- A trust rating before and after students see the same evidence.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Groups rewrite the event as a school announcement, tabloid headline, human rights report, police report, student activist post and parent message.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	The class identifies loaded words, omitted details and implied blame.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Students reconstruct the most neutral version possible.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Discuss whether complete neutrality is possible.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may say language merely expresses thought rather than shaping interpretation.
- Students may identify bias in extreme examples but miss subtle framing.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Explains how wording changes interpretation before evidence is judged.
- Uses concrete language choices as evidence for a TOK claim.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Metaphor Changes Policy
- Translation Loss Game
- Category Boundary Sorting